1

IN PURSUIT OF FRIENDSHIP

INDIA'S QUEST IN AFGHANISTAN

'The enemy, however strong he may be, becomes vulnerable to harassment and destruction when he is squeezed between the conqueror and his allies'.

Kautilya in the *Arthashastra*, Verse 6.2.40[1]

'As Pakistan increasingly became our problem, Afghanistan emerged as kind of a counter-balance. To keep Pakistan on its toes, friendly relations with Afghanistan, which always created a kind of anxiety in Pakistan, were kept up'.

Lalit Mansingh, Foreign Secretary of India (1999–2001)[2]

The question

Already being termed an 'Asian century', rising powers such as India have a greater say in international politics today. India's arrival on the international stage, however, has raised more questions than it has provided answers. Culturally heterogeneous but socially conservative; democratic but also housing various forms of extremism; territorially united but wrought with separatism; economically strong(er) but highly unequal; constitutionally secular but divided by religion, caste, and gender; rising peacefully but making its neighbours anxious; aspiring to be a global power yet shy (or unclear) of taking the lead—